

From digital visibility to attendance intention: the role of short-form content in shaping the perceived value of opera among young audiences

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Master's Thesis

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Universitat Autònoma de Barcelona

September 2026

Abstract

This thesis investigates how short-form digital content on social media shapes opera's perceived value among young audiences with varying familiarity with opera, and under what conditions this translates into attendance intention. Fourteen semi-structured interviews were conducted: six industry participants and eight with audience members from Chile, Colombia, Spain, and Ireland. These were analysed thematically and interpreted through the Theory of Consumption Values, cultural capital theory, Uses and Gratifications Theory, and the Experience Economy. Results indicate that humanising, process-revealing content was the type most consistently mentioned or valued across interviews, raised independently by nine of fourteen participants, and that its relationship to attendance is typically gradual rather than direct. Participants' accounts suggest that this relationship is shaped by personal networks, how price is framed, and non-financial barriers. The study extends prior research on opera streaming to short-form content and younger audiences, and offers recommendations on relationship-building infrastructure, content strategy, and reducing practical access barriers.

Keywords: Opera marketing, social media, short-form digital content, perceived value, cultural capital, attendance intention, access barriers

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1. Introduction

The starting point for this thesis was not a gap in the academic literature, but a controversy. In early 2026, actor Timothée Chalamet remarked in an interview that he did not want to be “working in ballet or opera, or, you know, things where it’s like, ‘Hey, keep this thing alive,’ even though like no one cares about this anymore.” (Variety, 2026). Initial interest in the topic came directly from encountering this controversy and the volume of reaction it produced, and from a simple observation that followed it: a single celebrity comment, dismissive in tone, appeared to generate a striking amount of public engagement with opera in only a few days, at a scale that felt, anecdotally, disproportionate to typical institutional marketing efforts. Whatever the comment's intent, its effect closely resembled free promotion for opera houses and the art form itself. That motivate to look more closely at the relationship between digital attention and opera's public image.

Further into the subject while developing this thesis, the researcher revealed something had not fully appreciated before. That opera, despite being sung in unfamiliar languages and staged in unfamiliar conventions, is built from music that already circulates constantly in everyday life, in film scores, in advertising, in moments of popular culture, largely without audiences recognising its origin. What had initially felt distant became, on closer engagement, considerably more familiar than expected. This personal shift in perception, from opera as something remote to something already quietly present in daily cultural life, became a central intuition behind this thesis's research question. This shift was reinforced directly during the research process itself, through attendance at a live performance at the Gran Teatre del Liceu in Barcelona, undertaken as contextual familiarisation with the subject matter rather than as research data. Understanding how young people come to find opera interesting and specifically what role short-form social-media content plays in that process, felt like the natural question to pursue from there.

Short-form digital content refers to video content, typically under three minutes in length, distributed on platforms including Instagram, TikTok, and YouTube Shorts, and consumed in a rapid, low-commitment manner distinct from full-length streamed performance, the focus of the most closely related prior research (Ouazzani et al., 2022a, 2022b). Perceived value is treated throughout this thesis as multidimensional rather than a single, undifferentiated sense of worth, following the Theory of Consumption Values (Sheth, Newman, & Gross, 1991). This distinction is important because one of the main arguments of this paper is that content in condensed form can influence certain dimensions of value to a much greater extent than others.

Existing research establishes strong foundations on either side of the relationship this thesis investigates but has not yet connected them directly. Prior work on opera streaming has examined full-length performance among an already-engaged audience (Ouazzani et al., 2022a, 2022b), while research on short-form video platforms has established general patterns of youth media use without reference to opera specifically. This thesis is positioned at the intersection of these two literatures. It asks not simply whether short-form opera content is produced or consumed, both already well established, but whether, how, and under what conditions it shapes perceived value in a way that plausibly connects to attendance intention, drawing on the direct testimony of both the industry professionals producing such content and the young audiences encountering it.

Research Question: How does short-form digital content on social media shape opera's perceived value among young audiences with varying levels of familiarity with opera, and under what conditions does this translate into attendance intention?

The objective of this thesis is practical as well as academic: to generate insight, grounded directly in young audiences' own accounts, that opera institutions can draw on when deciding how, and through what kind of content, to attract this audience specifically.

- (i) To identify which dimensions of perceived value: functional, social, emotional, epistemic, and conditional, are shaped by short-form digital content among young audiences with varying levels of familiarity with opera.
- (ii) To examine the extent to which cultural capital, familiarity, and perceived legitimacy, independent of price, function as barriers to engagement with opera, and whether short-form content addresses these barriers.
- (iii) To identify the specific gratifications and motivations driving engagement with short-form opera content, and to distinguish these from motivations relating to live attendance itself.
- (iv) To compare industry and audience perspectives directly, to identify the conditions under which perceived value shaped by digital content translates, or fails to translate, into attendance intention, and to surface practical insight, drawn from young audience members themselves, that institutions can use to inform future content and audience-development strategy.

2. Literature Review and Theoretical Framework

Opera occupies a paradoxical position in contemporary cultural consumption. On the one hand, attendance data from major institutions point to a structurally ageing audience. The Metropolitan Opera reported an average single-ticket buyer age of 44 during the 2024–25 season, compared with an average of 50 before the COVID-19 pandemic. It also reported a year-on-year decline in new ticket buyers, from 85,000 to 76,000 (OperaWire, 2025).

On the other hand, OPERA America's national study of more than 11,000 opera-goers surveyed between 2020 and 2024 identified record levels of first-time attendance across 36 companies. This led the organisation to examine not whether newcomers could be attracted, but how they might be converted into a continuing audience rather than remaining one-time visitors (OPERA America, 2024).

This tension between an ageing core audience and continuing first-time interest frames the central problem of this study. Attracting a first visit appears possible but converting exposure whether live or mediated into sustained perceived, value and future attendance intention, remains poorly understood. This issue is particularly relevant for audiences whose first point of contact with opera may occur through short-form digital content rather than through family, education, or established cultural networks.

The COVID-19 pandemic accelerated the use of digital and streamed opera. Ouazzani et al. (2022a) argue that online streaming, initially adopted by opera houses in response to lockdown closures, can remain a development opportunity after the return of live performances. Streaming may help institutions reach audiences facing geographical, financial, or time-related constraints and may support efforts to broaden an audience base that otherwise remains strongly connected to existing patrons.

Ouazzani et al. (2022a, 2022b) examined how audiences value streamed opera and how this experience differs from live attendance. Their findings suggest that streamed and live opera are valued through partly different dimensions, meaning that streaming should not be understood simply as an inferior substitute for attending a performance in person. This research provides an important starting point for the present study. Whereas Ouazzani and colleagues examined full-length streamed performances, this thesis focuses on short-form social-media content and on young audiences with varying levels of familiarity with opera.

Research on related mediated formats supports the view that digital exposure does not simply replace live attendance. Using data from the Spanish Survey of Cultural Habits and Practices, De la Vega et al. (2020) found that online and live consumers of highbrow performing arts have distinct behavioural profiles. Their findings also suggest that online

consumption does not straightforwardly substitute for live attendance when access is constrained. Similarly, Gutierrez-Navratil et al. (2024) found that live cinema broadcasts of performing arts can attract audiences who would not otherwise attend a live venue. They therefore position cinema broadcasts as an access channel rather than as merely a lesser version of live performance.

The digital transformation of opera institutions has also been examined from a management perspective. Bellini and Raglianti (2023) analysed the dynamic capabilities that Italian opera houses used during the pandemic. They found that institutions with pre-existing digital capacities adapted more readily, whereas others treated digital initiatives as temporary or reluctant responses. Ducros Passebois et al. (2019), examining the Opéra de Paris, similarly showed that digital branding requires institutions to negotiate between traditional prestige and the more informal, personality-driven communication associated with social media.

2.1 Short-Form Digital Content and Cultural Engagement

Compared with opera streaming, the literature on short-form video and digital audience development remains less developed in the specific context of opera. However, research in adjacent cultural sectors provides useful evidence about how cultural organisations use short-form platforms.

Huebner (2022) analysed TikTok content produced by museums and identified both expository and performative approaches to museum education. This suggests that cultural institutions use short-form video not only to present information but also to adapt educational content to the participatory and entertainment-oriented conventions of the platform. Huebner's (2023) qualitative study further found that short-form videos can support learning about art among young people, while also showing that the relationship between educators and audiences becomes more complex when education takes place through social media.

These findings are relevant to opera because they indicate that short-form cultural content may provide epistemic value by helping audiences encounter unfamiliar works, artists, and production processes. They also suggest that cultural institutions must balance educational aims with the informal, visual, and participatory expectations of social-media users. The museum context is not identical to opera, but it offers a useful comparison because both involve institutions attempting to make established cultural forms more accessible through digital platforms.

Carignani, Iodice, and Bifulco (2024) examined TikTok from a museum-management perspective and found that the platform can function as a strategic tool for cultural institutions seeking to increase visibility and communicate with audiences through more informal formats.

Their study is particularly relevant to the institutional dimension of the present thesis because it treats short-form video not simply as a communication channel but as part of broader organisational and audience-development strategy.

Recent research has also begun to examine the relationship between the formal features of cultural short-form videos and user engagement. Chek et al. (2024) analysed multimodal cues in museum TikTok videos, focusing on how visual and audiovisual features may be associated with user engagement. Such work suggests that the reception of cultural content is influenced not only by its subject matter but also by how the content is structured and presented. This is relevant to the present study's focus on backstage footage, performer-centred content, explanatory material, and other format preferences.

Together, these studies suggest that short-form cultural content can serve several functions: education, informal storytelling, institutional visibility, audience interaction, and community-building. Nevertheless, most existing research focuses on museums rather than opera and tends to examine visibility or engagement rather than perceived value and attendance intention. The present thesis addresses this gap by examining how short-form opera content may influence young audiences' perceptions of the art form and how this influence may relate to the possibility of attending a live performance.

2.2 Theory of Consumption Values

The Theory of Consumption Values (TCV), developed by Sheth, Newman, and Gross (1991), proposes that consumer choice is shaped by five value dimensions: functional, social, emotional, epistemic, and conditional value. Functional value concerns the practical utility or performance of a choice. Social value concerns the extent to which a choice is associated with a particular social group or image. Emotional value refers to the feelings generated by a choice. Epistemic value concerns curiosity, novelty, and the acquisition of knowledge. Conditional value refers to value that depends on a particular situation or set of circumstances.

TCV was developed as a general model of consumer choice and has been applied across a wide range of products and services. Within opera research, Ouazzani, Calderón-García, and Tubillejas-Andrés (2022a) examined the value sources of streamed opera consumption and their relationship to loyalty and intention to attend a live performance. Their findings indicated that hedonic, epistemic, and functional value influenced loyalty through different behavioural pathways.

A related study by Ouazzani et al. (2022b) examined differences between live and virtual opera experiences. It found that the two modes of consumption were valued through different dimensions rather than one functioning simply as a reduced version of the other. These

findings provide a relevant basis for distinguishing short-form digital content from live attendance in the present study.

TCV is particularly appropriate for this thesis because the research question concerns how audiences perceive the value of opera. It also provides a shared vocabulary for comparing industry and audience perspectives. For example, an industry participant's explanation of why backstage content was created and an audience participant's explanation of why that content was engaging can both be considered accounts of value.

Functional value is relevant to ticket price, discounts, seating categories, and the practical usefulness of short-form content as a discovery or planning tool. Social value is relevant to personal recommendations, performer-related engagement, private sharing, and attendance as a shared activity. Emotional value is relevant to participants' descriptions of opera-related content as calming, meaningful, moving, or personally significant. Epistemic value is relevant to curiosity about unfamiliar repertoire, performance processes, and suitable choices for a first opera. Conditional value is relevant where circumstances—such as a discount, a school encounter, a cinema broadcast, travel, or access to a personal network—make engagement possible.

Research on museum education supports the relevance of epistemic and emotional value in digital cultural engagement. Huebner (2023) found that social media can function as an educational environment in which young people encounter and learn about art through short-form content. However, this source does not examine opera or attendance intention and is therefore used here as adjacent cultural-sector literature rather than as direct evidence for opera consumption.

In this thesis, the five TCV dimensions are treated as analytical possibilities rather than as assumptions that must all be equally supported. The empirical analysis therefore examines which dimensions emerge most clearly from participants' accounts and which appear only selectively.

2.3 Cultural Capital Theory (Bourdieu)

Pierre Bourdieu's concept of cultural capital, developed most fully in *Distinction: A Social Critique of the Judgement of Taste* (Bourdieu, 1984) and in his discussion of the forms of capital (Bourdieu, 1986), holds that taste and cultural consumption are shaped by socially and educationally acquired dispositions. These dispositions, or *habitus*, are unevenly distributed across social groups.

Within this framework, unfamiliarity with the codes, conventions, and expected behaviours of a cultural field can create the sense that a particular cultural practice is “not for

people like me.” This form of exclusion is not necessarily financial. It may also involve uncertainty about language, dress, behaviour, appropriate knowledge, or the kinds of people expected to participate.

Benzecry’s (2009) ethnographic study of opera fandom in Buenos Aires offers an important qualification of Bourdieu’s account. Based on eighteen months of fieldwork among opera fans at the Colón Opera House, Benzecry argues that opera appreciation is not simply inherited from one’s social background. It can also be actively assembled through initiation and apprenticeship. Fans develop their appreciation because they believe opera is something that must be learned.

This perspective is relevant to the present study because participants described interest in opera as something that could develop through repeated exposure, education, and direct experience. It also supports treating cultural capital as something that may be built over time rather than as a fixed quality that an individual either possesses or lacks.

The present study applies cultural-capital theory to participants’ accounts of unfamiliarity, legitimacy, intimidation, and perceived exclusivity. It also considers whether short-form content can reduce some of these barriers by making performers, processes, and expectations more visible.

2.4 Uses and Gratifications Theory

Uses and Gratifications Theory (U&G), first systematically articulated by Katz, Blumler, and Gurevitch (1974), proposes that media audiences are active rather than passive. Individuals select and use media to satisfy psychological and social needs instead of being affected uniformly by content.

Katz et al. (1974) framed the research agenda around the origins of social and psychological needs, the expectations these needs generate, patterns of media exposure, and the gratifications that result. U&G is therefore relevant to this thesis because it helps distinguish why audiences engage with short-form content from what institutions intend that content to achieve.

Research on young adults’ TikTok use identified motivations including realism, community building, browsing, variety-seeking, and play (Vaterlaus & Winter, 2021). These motivations provide a useful basis for examining whether audiences engage with opera-related content for entertainment, curiosity, information, mood regulation, social connection, or performer-related interest.

Huebner’s (2022, 2023) research on museum education provides related evidence from the cultural sector. Although her studies are not framed as U&G research, they show that young

audiences may use social-media content to learn about art and cultural institutions. These studies should therefore be treated as complementary literature on digital cultural engagement rather than as direct evidence supporting U&G.

In the present study, U&G is used when participants explicitly described a motivation for consuming short-form content. These motivations are distinguished from motivations for live attendance, which may involve social occasion, emotional immersion, sensory experience, novelty, or the desire to participate in a shared cultural event.

2.5 Experience Economy

The Experience Economy framework, introduced by Pine and Gilmore (1998, 1999) and later revised by Pine and Gilmore (2011), argues that economic value increasingly derives from staged and memorable experiences rather than from goods or services alone. Pine and Gilmore distinguish four realms of experience according to active or passive participation and absorption or immersion: entertainment, education, escapism, and aesthetic experience.

The framework is relevant to opera because live performance involves more than the artistic content alone. It includes the venue, architecture, performers, audience, atmosphere, sound, visual design, and the social conditions of attendance. These elements contribute to the value of the live experience and cannot be reproduced fully through short-form content. Tubillejas-Andrés et al. (2020) provides an empirical connection between this framework and opera. Their study examined how emotional responses to the physical and social setting of opera events influenced post-consumption outcomes. Their findings support the view that the broader environment of an opera event contributes to satisfaction and behavioural intention.

Ouazzani et al.'s (2022b) comparison of live and streamed opera further supports treating the live experience as qualitatively distinct from its mediated forms. Short-form content can reveal aspects of the people and processes behind a production, but it offers a different form of participation from attending an opera in person.

The Experience Economy is therefore used in this thesis primarily to interpret the distinction between mediated content and live attendance. It is not treated as a coding category alongside TCV, cultural capital, and U&G. Instead, it provides a framework for understanding what may remain specific to the live experience after audiences have encountered opera digitally.

2.6 Research Gap

The literature reviewed above establishes several relevant points. Opera institutions are adapting to digital distribution, streamed and live experiences may provide different forms of

value, short-form cultural content can support education and institutional visibility, and cultural participation may be shaped by familiarity, social background, and perceived legitimacy.

However, existing research has not sufficiently connected these areas. Research on opera streaming has primarily examined full-length performances and audiences already engaged with opera. Research on short-form video has examined general media use, museum education, cultural-institution visibility, and platform engagement, but has rarely focused on opera. Research on cultural capital explains barriers of familiarity and legitimacy, while U&G helps explain motivations for media use and the Experience Economy highlights the distinct value of live experiences.

The specific gap addressed by this thesis concerns how short-form digital content shapes the perceived value of opera among young audiences with varying levels of familiarity, and under what conditions this may relate to attendance intention. The study also addresses a methodological gap by comparing the perspectives of industry professionals and audience participants within the same qualitative design.

The contribution of the present study is therefore not to establish a causal relationship between short-form content and attendance. Rather, it is to describe the possible pathways through which digital content may influence familiarity, curiosity, emotional connection, and perceived accessibility, while identifying the personal, algorithmic, practical, cultural, and institutional conditions that may facilitate or limit this process.

3. Methodology and Research Design

To investigate how short-form digital content on social media relates to opera's perceived value among young audiences with varying levels of familiarity with opera, this study adopted a qualitative, interview-based approach. Primary data were collected through semi-structured interviews with two distinct groups of informants: industry professionals, including opera house managers, digital content strategists, and opera-related social media influencers; and audience members, up to 35 years old, with varying levels of familiarity with opera. This dual-group design allows the study to compare complementary supply-side perspectives, those producing and distributing opera-related content on social media, with audience-side perspectives, exploring how young or occasional audiences' perceptions and attendance intentions relate to that content. Participant selection was guided by two main criteria. First, young audiences with varying levels of familiarity with opera. Every participant had attended at least one live opera performance, ensuring that all informants could draw on some direct, first-hand experience of opera rather than relying solely on second-hand impressions.

Audience participants varied considerably in their relationship to opera, ranging from occasional attendees with limited exposure to individuals with closer personal or professional ties to the art form, including opera fans, singing students, musicians, dancers, and people working in theatre. This variation is reflected in the participant profiles presented below. Second, participants were selected because they had a meaningful connection to the research topic, whether professionally, through content creation, or through active interest as audience members. Sampling combined several strategies.

Participants were selected purposively, based on their relevance to the research question, and were reached primarily through direct personal outreach by the researcher. In addition, a small number of participants were recruited through informal snowball recruitment, having learned of the study through participants or contacts already involved, and others self-selected by contacting the researcher directly after encountering the project. Because participants were, by design or by self-selection, already engaged enough with opera to agree to participate, the sample likely over-represents individuals with a positive predisposition toward opera and its digital presence. This is acknowledged as a limitation of the study. Before the main data collection phase, a pilot interview was conducted to test the interview guide and sampling approach. The participant had very limited familiarity with opera and the conversation revealed the need for a more open and focused guide.

Additionally, a technical recording failure during this interview further highlighted the need to refine both the sample and the question guide before proceeding. For these reasons, this interview was not included in the final analytical sample of fourteen interviews reported below. A personal attendance at a live performance at the Liceu, referenced in the Introduction, is presented as contextual familiarisation with the subject matter and does not constitute part of the analytical data reported in this study. This approach ultimately allowed the study to compare participants' real-life experience of opera with their consumption of short-form content about it and to draw out their perspectives on the future of opera within a social-media and short-form content landscape.

3.1 Recruitment and Access

Interviewees were recruited through a combination of email outreach, LinkedIn messaging, and Instagram direct messaging. The six industry and professional participants were recruited through two routes: four were contacted with the help of the researcher's supervisor, who provided introductions and contacts, while the remaining two were contacted directly by the researcher.

Also to facilitate access to opera professionals and influencers active on social media, a dedicated Instagram profile was created specifically for this research project. This profile then was used also to recruit audience members, allowing the researcher to identify and reach individuals who were at least somewhat interested in opera and active on social media, and through this, to explore their platform habits, the type of short-form content they engaged with, and how algorithmic content delivery shaped their exposure to opera-related material.

Outreach messages were kept warm and personal rather than generic, typically introducing the researcher, expressing genuine interest in the recipient's profile and inviting them to contribute to the master's thesis through a short 45 to 60-minute interview. Through this profile, 26 individuals were contacted directly; of these, 12 responded, resulting in 5 interviews. In addition, 3 participants reached out to the researcher on their own initiative after seeing the project shared or discussed by others, expressing interest in contributing their perspective.

This profile also served as a credible point of contact, allowing the researcher to introduce the study, its academic purpose and its scope directly to potential participants within the same platform ecosystem under investigation. This approach proved effective overall: participants were generally receptive and expressed genuine interest in the topic, several noting that they rarely encountered academic research engaging seriously with opera's digital presence.

3.2 Data Collection

Interviews were conducted over two weeks in July 2026. Most interviews were held remotely via Zoom, Instagram video call, or WhatsApp video call, scheduled by mutual agreement with participants. Two interviews with audience members were conducted in person, in a café. Each interview followed a semi-structured interview guide. A base interview guide was developed for audience-member participants, prepared in two language versions, English and Spanish, since interviews were conducted in the participant's preferred language while the thesis itself is written in English.

For industry professionals and influencers, interviews were built around a common core of questions shared across this group, with additional questions adapted to each participant's specific role, institution, or area of expertise. This ensured comparability across professional interviews while still allowing depth on each participant's particular experience. This individualised set of questions was likewise prepared in both languages. Every interview began with a short profiling segment in which participants were asked to describe their background, role, and relationship to opera, which later allowed for the construction of the participant profile table below.

Before each interview, participants were given a short opening briefing. This introduced the researcher and the purpose of the study, that is, understanding how young people discover and relate to opera through social media and clarified that the interview was not a test of their opera knowledge, but an exploration of their personal experience and opinions, for which there were no right or wrong answers. Participants were asked for permission to record the conversation, and were informed that the recording would be transcribed, anonymised, and subsequently deleted, and that their name would not appear in any written material. Participants were given the opportunity to ask questions before the interview began.

The full interview opening script and guide are provided in Appendix. All interviews were audio-recorded on the researcher's personal device and archived using a file-naming convention based on the participant's name. Recordings were subsequently transcribed using the transcription software TurboScribe, which in several cases also auto-translated Spanish-language interviews into English. Each transcript was manually checked against the original recording, with Spanish-language interviews reviewed two to three times to verify the accuracy of both the transcription and the translation. Conducting interviews in Spanish while writing the thesis in English introduced an additional layer of translation and interpretation, which is acknowledged as a methodological consideration.

3.3 Participant Profiles

Table 1. Industry and Professional Profiles

	Age (in years)	Profile	Interview duration (in minutes)	Number of transcribed pages
M1	55	Senior professional in opera-related digital media	45 min	12
M2	37	Staff member at a major cultural institution	58 min	16
M3	n/a	Former staff member at a cultural institution	46 min	16
M4	65	Public-sector cultural professional	47 min	14
M5	27	Opera-focused social-media creator	35 min	11
M6	44	Former performing-arts production professional	60 min	16

Source: own elaboration based on interview data.

Table 2. Audience Profiles

	Age (in years)	Nationality	Profile	Interview duration	Number of transcribed pages
A1	26	Chile	Film director	45 min	18
A2	33	Chile	Works in theatre	46 min	15
A3	26	Spain	Dancer	56 min	15
A4	21	Spain	Singing student	79 min	18
A5	19	Spain	Opera fan	52 min	14
A6	34	Ireland	Amateur musician	49 min	22
A7	25	Colombia	Singing student	55 min	12
A8	32	Spain	Newly interested in opera	42 min	11

Source: own elaboration based on interview data.

In total, fourteen semi-structured interviews were conducted for this study and included in the final analytical sample: six with industry professionals and social media influencers connected to opera institutions, and eight with audience members reflecting a range of ages, nationalities,

and levels of familiarity with opera. An additional pilot interview was conducted before the main data collection phase but was excluded from both the interview count and the recorded-hours and transcribed-pages totals reported above. Participants ranged in age from nineteen to sixty-five, with age information unavailable for one professional participant. Combined, the fourteen interviews yielded approximately twelve hours and eleven minutes of recorded material, later transcribed into 210 pages of text.

All participants have been anonymised in this thesis and are identified only by role and profile descriptors, for example M1 or A8, to protect their privacy while preserving the contextual detail necessary for analysis. This sample and data collection process are subject to further limitations. The use of different interview modes, remote video calls versus in-person conversations in a café, and different interview languages, English and Spanish, introduces some variation in interview format and in the layer of translation and interpretation involved in analyzing the Spanish-language material. Additionally, while transcripts and translations were manually checked against the original recordings, reliance on automatic transcription and translation software carries some residual risk of inaccuracy. These limitations are considered further in the discussion of findings.

3.4 Data Analysis

Data analysis followed Braun and Clarke's (2006) approach to inductive, thematic analysis, beginning close to the data through open coding, before theoretical frameworks were introduced to interpret emerging patterns. Each interview recording was listened to carefully, and passages considered relevant to the research question were highlighted. For each highlighted passage, an initial code was assigned, a short label capturing its content or meaning, for example “social media” or “community”, generated directly from what the participant said rather than from a predetermined list. These initial codes were logged in a structured Excel spreadsheet alongside their source interview. Within each interview, related initial codes were grouped into a single, more consolidated code once the full transcript had been reviewed.

As subsequent interviews were coded, newly generated codes were compared against those already logged; where a code from a new interview reflected the same or a closely related idea to an existing one, the two were merged, with a note recording whether participants' perspectives converged, diverged, or partially overlapped. Industry professionals and audience members were coded together as a single combined set, rather than analysed as two separate groups, allowing codes to emerge across both perspectives before any comparison between them was made.

This process was repeated across all fourteen interviews, producing a working set of approximately eighty initial codes, in addition to a small number of codes reflecting explicit points of disagreement between participants rather than a shared pattern. Coding has since been completed across all fourteen interviews. The resulting codes were reviewed, compared, and consolidated into a smaller number of broader themes and subthemes based on shared subject matter and recurrence across the sample, producing five overarching themes comprising sixteen subthemes in total.

Codes reflecting a genuine point of disagreement between participants, rather than a shared pattern, were retained as explicitly flagged divergences rather than merged into a theme, since meaningful variation between participants is treated here as analytically significant rather than as noise to be resolved. At this stage, the study's theoretical frameworks were used to interpret the resulting themes, with each theme assigned a single primary framework rather than multiple simultaneous tags, to preserve analytical clarity and avoid overlapping or duplicated interpretation.

The Theory of Consumption Values served as the primary interpretive lens, given the centrality of perceived value to the research question. Bourdieu's concept of cultural capital served as a complementary lens for themes concerning familiarity, legitimacy, and perceived barriers to access. Uses and Gratifications Theory was applied only where a specific media-use motivation, such as entertainment, information-seeking, curiosity, social connection, or mood management, was explicit in a participant's own account. The Experience Economy framework was reserved primarily as an interpretive lens for the discussion of findings rather than as a coding category, given conceptual overlap with the other three frameworks. Themes for which it remains especially relevant are noted accordingly and revisited.

4. Results

This chapter presents the themes identified through the thematic analysis of fourteen semi-structured interviews: six with industry professionals and social media influencers connected to opera (M1–M6), and eight with audience members (A1–A8). The coding process generated approximately 80 initial codes, which were subsequently consolidated into five overarching themes and 16 sub-themes. Six explicit points of divergence between participants were retained and analysed separately.

4.1 A. Discovery and Access Pathways

Three sub-themes emerged regarding discovery and access: personal-network-mediated access, passive and algorithmic discovery, and early and latent exposure.

4.1.1 A1 Personal Network Mediated Access

Participants described personal networks as one important route through which they encountered opera and attended performances. However, this pathway was not uniform: for some participants, personal connections enabled access, whereas others described social media as more useful when they lacked a stable local network.

A1 reported that his first attendance resulted from a friend's invitation rather than from independent interest, despite having encountered classical music through television during childhood: "I met her [opera] through a friend when... I was already a professional... I must have been 23 years old when I went for the first time."

A2 described a similar pattern across her broader experience of theatre and opera, stating that "90% of the works" she had seen were recommended by friends working in the performing arts. She added that people who attend theatre or opera "almost always have a link there, like a cousin... a friend who does this."

At the same time, A3 described social media as a more practical access route because her professional life involved frequent travel. For her, social media made it easier to discover cultural events in places where she did not have an established personal network. A7 provided a contrasting example: invitations to her own performances did not consistently result in attendance, even when they came from an existing personal relationship.

Taken together, these accounts suggest that personal networks can facilitate access, but their effect depends on the participant's circumstances and level of prior interest. They also indicate that social media may be particularly useful when individuals lack direct personal connections to opera, although this possibility requires further investigation.

4.1.2 A2. Passive and Algorithmic Digital Discovery

Three participants (A2, A6, and A7) described algorithmic feeds as reinforcing existing interests rather than introducing them to opera-related content. A2 stated that “the algorithm always throws you things that you want, things that you look for, and it never shows you new things.” She explained that before actively searching for opera, she encountered almost no opera-related content, despite already considering herself interested in cultural activities.

A6 offered a similar explanation for the absence of opera content from his feed, stating that “it’s not something that I search for,” and therefore the algorithm was unlikely to recommend it. A7, drawing on her experience with opera-house marketing, similarly argued that content would not reach users who had never demonstrated an interest in opera. She noted, however, that content related to ballet had reached her because she already had an interest in that field.

These accounts suggest that algorithmic discovery may not function as an open pathway into opera for users with no previous connection to the art form. Instead, it may extend existing interests or reach audiences through adjacent cultural fields. This finding is relevant to the research question because it qualifies the assumption that simply publishing short-form opera content will necessarily expose entirely new audiences to opera.

4.1.3 A3. Early and Latent Exposure

Three participants (A1, A4, and A5) described early encounters with opera that occurred before they became actively involved with the art form. A1 recalled hearing opera through childhood television broadcasts in Chile and described an intense emotional reaction: “I found the music so beautiful... I started crying.” A4 associated her interest with a school music class in which a teacher showed a recording of Montserrat Caballé. A5 similarly recalled encountering *The Magic Flute* in a music class at the age of ten, after which she asked her family to take her to the opera.

These accounts indicate that prior familiarity may begin through incidental or educational exposure rather than through short-form digital content. Although these early encounters were not themselves examples of social-media exposure, they may shape how later opera-related digital content is received by creating an initial point of recognition or openness. Early exposure therefore appears relevant to the research question as a possible background condition influencing the effect of subsequent short-form content.

4.2 B. Content Engagement and Format Preferences

Four sub-themes emerged regarding content engagement and format preferences: backstage and humanising content; curated, risk-reduced entry-level content; content-driven reach beyond the existing niche; and emotional and parasocial engagement mechanisms.

4.2.1 B1. Backstage and Humanising Content

Backstage and humanising content was the most frequently mentioned content type in the dataset. Nine participants from both groups (M1, M2, M4, M5, M6, A1, A3, A5, and A6) referred to content showing the preparation, production process, or personal lives of opera professionals.

Industry participants described this content as a way of making opera and the theatre more approachable. M2 referred to showing the work of dressing-room staff, lighting technicians, and stage machinists, with each person explaining their role directly to camera. M5 described a video following a singer while she prepared for a performance and explained that the purpose was “to humanise the opera in some way so that people aren’t afraid of it.”

Audience participants described a similar response. A1 emphasised that opera singers were “normal people,” while A3 said that videos showing make-up application, lighting, and direction made her stop scrolling because this information was less familiar to her than footage of a singer performing. A6 compared the appeal of such content to reality television, explaining that viewers want to see “the person behind the show.”

The convergence between professional intentions and audience responses is notable. In this sample, process-based content appeared to reduce the distance between audiences and the institution by making the people and work behind the performance visible. This may help explain why it was mentioned more frequently than content focused only on the finished performance.

4.2.2 B2. Curated, Risk-Reduced Entry-Level Content

Four participants (M5, M6, A3, and A4) described selecting operas for first-time attendees and distinguishing between works they considered accessible and those they considered unsuitable for beginners. M1 described short-form content as allowing viewers to “get a taste” of a performance before committing to an entire evening.

M6 recommended works such as *Madama Butterfly* and other Puccini operas as suitable introductions, while identifying *Lulu* and *Wozzeck* as more difficult starting points. A3 and A4 similarly advised against recommending Wagner to first-time attendees. A4 explained that prior knowledge of a composer did not necessarily make a demanding performance easy to experience. M5 described a related form of guidance. After encountering

his content, viewers sometimes contacted him privately to ask which opera they should attend first in a particular city.

These accounts suggest that short-form content may reduce uncertainty not only by showing what an opera looks like, but also by helping audiences select an appropriate first performance. The perceived risk addressed here is primarily experiential rather than financial: participants were concerned that a difficult first encounter might discourage further interest.

4.2.3 B3. Content-Driven Reach Beyond the Existing Niche

Several participants described specific mechanisms by which content can extend beyond an institution's or creator's existing, already-engaged audience. M2 identified audience saturation as a structural limit on genre-specific influencers: “you have 50,000 followers, but the people who are there are always the same 500. So, once you have reached those 500, you don’t contribute much more.” He contrasted this with content bridged through creators in adjacent, non-opera domains, which he described as more effective at reaching genuinely new viewers. M2 additionally argued that reach beyond the niche depends on repetition rather than a single instance of exposure: “a single video of a minute that appears to you once means nothing... several videos strategically designed and over time put in front of the same audience can probably generate that change.” M1 offered a related account grounded in attention rather than repetition, comparing audience behavior on platforms like Spotify to selective listening: users “will be selective... won’t listen to the same track over and over again, rather than all 10 tracks.” Two participants pointed to virality as a distinct, largely uncontrollable mechanism.

M4 noted that the single most successful piece of opera content he was aware of was an unplanned on-stage incident, not a designed marketing asset, while A1 confirmed the reach of a comparable unplanned event (a public controversy) from the audience side, describing unusually high engagement (“it never had so many likes, it never had so many comments”).

M5 described a content philosophy explicitly designed for durability rather than virality, favouring “perennial” content over trend-driven material: “even if it’s a bullshit... a soprano, it will continue to be a soprano in ten years, or Mozart, it will continue to be Mozart.” A1 gave a concrete audience-side account of a specific staging choice that captured attention outside the existing opera-going public a production that integrated cinematic visual techniques into a live staging, which he believed “captivated young people” specifically because of its hybridity with a familiar media form.

4.2.4 B4. Emotional and Parasocial Engagement Mechanisms

Direct parasocial contact with performers emerged as a further engagement mechanism, though participants described this at different levels of intensity. A5 described actively

messaging established singers directly and receiving responses “without any problem,” treating this as a normalized practice among highly engaged fans. A5 also described a shift in her own association with Turandot. She characterised "Nessun Dorma" as the reflexive association anyone unfamiliar with opera defaults to ("the person who doesn't know opera will always go to Nessun Dorma, and that's it"). After watching short videos covering the opera's choir and characters, that single-aria association no longer dominated her thinking: "when I think of Turandot, the last thing I think of is Nessun Dorma." repeated content exposure did not introduce her to Turandot for the first time, but broadened a previously narrow, single-aria association into a fuller one.

A3 described a comparatively lighter version of the same behavior, following performers' personal accounts rather than contacting them directly. M6 described short-form opera content serving an emotion-regulation function distinct from any parasocial or informational motive, characterising it as “a little... breaking my day... I feel calmer, I feel at ease,” unconnected to any intention to attend a performance.

Two participants, one industry and one audience, independently described opera as engaging a specific emotional register unavailable through other media, in language that converged closely despite being generated separately. A1 described opera as “complete arts,” combining “music... theatre... design, architecture, wardrobe design, art direction, sound design,” while M6 described it as accessing “very real and relatable emotions and human experiences... in a way that we can't through just talking or just reading.” A2 described two further gratifications distinct from entertainment: a therapeutic, identity-related motivation for consuming art generally (“art helps me a lot... to understand myself too, to feel less alone”), and distinctly positive response.

4.3 C. Barriers to Attendance

Three sub-themes emerged regarding barriers to attendance: price, duration and format, and cultural capital and perceived legitimacy.

4.3.1 C1. Price as a Contested and Variable Barrier

Participants offered different accounts of the extent to which price limits attendance. Some described opera tickets as expensive, while others considered them affordable when compared with other forms of entertainment or when different seating categories and discounts were considered.

M5 viewed opera as relatively inaccessible in comparison with other leisure activities, noting that attending a theatre performance could cost around €90. He suggested that opera was often perceived as a particularly demanding or “intellectual” form of entertainment, which

made the price seem more difficult to justify. M4 similarly emphasised that the cost of attending opera depends heavily on the venue and seating category, comparing ticket prices in Vienna, New York, and Berlin.

Other participants described more affordable options. A1 noted that young people in Chile could sometimes attend for as little as one euro, although many potential attendees were unaware of these prices. A3 described a wide range of seating options within the same venue, from approximately €200 for a premium seat to around €30 for a less central location. A4 compared opera prices with major pop concerts, arguing that young people may be willing to spend large amounts on artists such as Bad Bunny or Taylor Swift, while A7 stated that tickets costing €15 or €20 could be “very achievable.”

However, the interviews also indicated that price cannot always be separated from perceptions of exclusivity and social legitimacy. M2 described people who avoided opera because they believed it was too elite, lacked appropriate clothing, or could not afford it. This reluctance reportedly remained even when free tickets were offered. M6 similarly recalled abandoning a planned visit because the available seats were too expensive, while contrasting this experience with more affordable opera tickets in the United States.

Overall, participants did not present price as a uniform barrier. Its importance appeared to depend on the venue, seating category, local pricing structure, availability of discounts, and comparisons with other forms of leisure. The accounts also suggest that perceived expense may be reinforced by assumptions about opera as an exclusive activity, meaning that clearer communication about prices and available options may be relevant to attendance intention.

4.3.2 C2. Duration and Format as an Attentional Barrier

Two participants (A3, A7) described the length of a typical opera performance as a barrier to attention or engagement, independent of price or content. A3 described this as a factor separate from language: “there are operas that are 4 hours long, how young will they go? That doesn’t help.” She described her own difficulty maintaining attention during a three-hour performance of *Aida*, reporting that she reached “a point where I say, oh my god, stop it” and had on occasion, used her phone during the performance.

A7 proposed a specific edit to a canonical work as an example of unnecessary length, contrasting the historical context in which operas were composed with contemporary attention spans, suggesting that “*La Traviata*[’s] second act could be summed up in 15 minutes,” describing it specifically as “filler.”

4.3.3 C3. Cultural Capital and Perceived Legitimacy Barriers

Participants described several barriers to opera that were unrelated to ticket price or performance length. These included unfamiliarity with opera's conventions, uncertainty about appropriate behaviour, perceptions of social exclusivity, and doubts about whether opera was intended for people like them.

M1 suggested that digital content could reduce some of these perceived social barriers by allowing audiences to engage with opera and its performers before attending a venue. M3 similarly argued that price was "only part of the solution," indicating that reducing financial barriers would not necessarily remove feelings of exclusion. M5 provided a personal example, explaining that he found the Teatro Real intimidating despite having substantial musical training.

Several participants described how direct experience could challenge these perceptions. A2 stated that attending a performance changed her previous assumption that opera was exclusive and led her to conclude that it was something "anyone can enjoy." A8 similarly described opera as having previously seemed like "only a genre for rich people," although his live experience began to weaken this belief. In both accounts, the change was associated with direct exposure to a performance rather than with short-form digital content encountered beforehand.

Participants also described familiarity with opera as something that can be developed over time. A4 stated that "interest is trained," while A7 explained that she initially found opera recordings difficult but that sustained exposure eventually made the art form "more friendly" and enjoyable. A4 additionally referred to opera-house architecture as communicating social distinctions, contrasting Bayreuth's sloped seating with traditional boxes associated with aristocratic families.

Finally, A5 identified a practical misconception among people attending opera for the first time: many believed that subtitles would not be provided and assumed that they would need to understand the original language. This example shows how a lack of basic information can reinforce the perception that opera is difficult or inaccessible.

Overall, these accounts suggest that cultural legitimacy barriers may persist even when tickets are affordable. Familiarising audiences with the people, conventions, spaces, and practical conditions surrounding opera may therefore be relevant to shaping perceived accessibility and attendance intention.

4.4 D. Institutional and Industry Strategy

Three sub-themes emerged regarding institutional and industry strategy: funding and organisational context, platform and promotional strategy, and institutional positioning and identity.

4.4.1 D1. Funding and Organisational Context

Participants described funding and organisational priorities as factors shaping an institution's ability and willingness to invest in short-form digital content. M4 suggested that heavy public subsidy may reduce the immediate commercial pressure to attract additional ticket buyers, while M3 emphasised that limited resources force institutions to choose among competing priorities, with young audiences representing only one segment.

These accounts suggest that the production of short-form content depends not only on creative ideas but also on institutional incentives, available resources, and the priority assigned to digital audience development.

4.4.2 D2. Platform and Promotional Strategy

Participants described several decisions affecting how short-form content reaches audiences. M3 argued that organic distribution may be insufficient, and that paid promotion can be necessary to increase visibility. M2 described adapting content to different platforms, noting that Facebook reached an older and more conservative audience than Instagram. M4 similarly associated Facebook with an audience aged over 40.

M2 also described a newsletter community that provided recurring contact with more than 2,500 young people. This example shows that institutions may combine social-media content with owned communication channels rather than relying exclusively on platform algorithms.

Participants also identified constraints affecting platform strategy. M3 explained that one institution had not opened a TikTok account because it lacked the resources to maintain the platform properly. M1 described an influencer collaboration in which the creator's independent opinion did not fully align with the institution's promotional aims. A7 similarly questioned whether institutions clearly define the young audience they are trying to reach.

Overall, the accounts suggest that platform choice, paid promotion, audience targeting, owned channels, and available resources all influence whether short-form content can reach younger audiences.

4.4.3 D3. Institutional Positioning and Identity

Participants described institutional identity as another factor shaping how opera is presented through digital content. M2 rejected an explicitly exclusive brand image and linked accessibility to affordable tickets and communication aimed at a wider public. He also explained that youth-oriented projects were more effective when designed for younger audiences from the beginning, rather than when existing content was adapted afterwards. M5 described a different positioning choice, deciding to produce opera content in Spanish rather than English to maintain a closer connection with his intended audience. A7 suggested that institutions could also make opera more accessible by experimenting with participatory formats, although this proposal concerns the broader performance experience rather than short-form content itself.

Together, these accounts suggest that short-form content is shaped by decisions about whom the institution wants to reach, which language it uses, and whether accessibility is incorporated into a project from the beginning. However, the interviews do not establish which positioning strategy is most effective in generating attendance intention.

4.5 E. Outcomes: Conversion and Audience Composition

Three sub-themes emerged regarding the outcomes of short-form content: direct and gradual pathways toward attendance, the perceived persistence of a niche- and insider-skewed audience, and non-purchase outcomes of content engagement.

4.5.1 E1. Direct and Gradual Pathways toward Attendance

Three participants (M5, A1, and A5) distinguished between two ways in which short-form content may relate to attendance. The first was a direct pathway, in which a specific piece of content was associated with a particular ticket purchase. The second was a gradual pathway, in which repeated exposure changed a person's general perception of opera without creating a traceable link to one purchase.

M5 acknowledged that direct links did occur, explaining that some viewers had discovered a particular performance through one of his videos. However, he considered this less common than the broader effect of making opera appear more accessible. He described these as two separate functions of his content: promoting a specific performance and “democratising” opera more generally.

A1 similarly viewed social media as capable of gradually widening opera's audience, although he expected opera to remain a niche art form for some time. A5 provided an example from her own experience, explaining that a series of short videos about *Turandot* changed which elements of the opera came to mind when she thought about it. This change occurred independently of a specific ticket purchase.

Overall, these accounts suggest that the relationship between short-form content and attendance intention may be gradual and cumulative rather than immediately traceable. Short-form content may first influence familiarity and general perceptions of opera, while a decision to attend may occur later and involve additional factors such as personal recommendations, price, availability, and practical access. Because this interpretation is based on retrospective accounts from three participants, it does not establish a causal relationship between content exposure and attendance.

4.5.2 E2. Perceived Persistence of a Niche- and Insider-Skewed Audience

Three participants (A1, A5, and A7) perceived the opera audience as relatively small and strongly connected to the existing field. A1 described seeing “the same” faces repeatedly at performances over several years. A5 referred to institutional concerns about whether opera would have a public in the future. A7, drawing on her experience in opera-house marketing, stated that many people who consume opera-related content are already connected to the field, which she referred to as “the Gremio.”

These accounts describe participants’ perceptions rather than an independently measured composition of the opera audience. They suggest that short-form content may continue to circulate substantially within an existing cultural network, although the present study cannot determine how widespread or durable this pattern is.

4.5.3 E3. Non-Purchase Outcomes of Content Engagement

Participants described several outcomes of engaging with opera-related content that did not involve buying a ticket or attending a performance. These included professional learning, emotional engagement, private sharing, practical communication, and a sense of belonging.

A4, a singing student, described keeping a repertoire folder of works discovered through social media to discuss with her singing teacher. A3 similarly connected content consumption with professional development, stating that “the more things I see, the more tools I think I will have.” These accounts suggest that short-form content can function as a source of learning and creative inspiration, rather than only as promotion.

Other participants described more personal forms of engagement. M6 used opera-related content to interrupt his daily routine and feel calmer and described sharing clips privately with specific people to encourage them to attend a performance. M5 reported receiving private messages from viewers asking for practical advice about opera events in their cities.

A8 described watching an opera broadcast with his mother primarily as a shared social experience rather than as an opportunity to study or appreciate the artist. He also reported that

a positive live experience did not lead him to follow the artists on social media. Because this observation comes from one participant, it should be treated as exploratory. It raises the possibility that attendance and later digital engagement do not always develop together, and that post-attendance engagement may require separate institutional strategies.

Finally, M6 described opera-related content as contributing to a sense of belonging in Barcelona as an immigrant or expatriate. This account shows that content engagement may also have a social and identity-related value that is not captured by attendance or purchase metrics.

Overall, these accounts indicate that the value of short-form opera content may extend beyond immediate attendance. It can support learning, emotional regulation, interpersonal communication, social connection, and belonging, although these outcomes were described by individual participants and should not be generalised to the wider audience

4.6 F. Divergent Perspectives

This section presents six points on which participants' accounts diverged. These are reported side by side, without resolution, as each reflects a genuinely different position.

Sampling content before committing, versus preferring to go straight to a live performance: M1 described short-form content as useful for obtaining “a taste” of an opera before committing to an entire evening. A1 expressed the opposite preference, stating that he would rather experience opera live without prior exposure.

Wanting narrative context before attending, versus preferring to go in without any: M6 preferred to receive an introduction to an unfamiliar opera before watching it. By contrast, A3 and A8 preferred to attend without researching the plot or receiving extensive prior explanation. A3 stated, “I want to go blank. Without expectations,” while A8 described spontaneous discovery as his ideal way of encountering opera.

Personality-driven content versus content without a personal focus: M5, M6, A1, and A3 described content focused on performers' personalities or daily lives as engaging. A4 expressed a different preference for content focused on musical knowledge without a strong personal focus, warning that it could otherwise become centred on “the ego.”

Opera as a response to social-media fatigue, versus a continuing preference for solitary digital leisure: M6 suggested that some young people may value opera as a break from constant digital consumption. A2 described a contrasting pattern in her social circle, where people increasingly preferred staying indoors and watching series or films rather than attending socially demanding live events.

Price as a barrier, versus price as a secondary factor: M3 suggested that price might not be the main obstacle to attendance. In contrast, M2, M4, and M6 described situations in which ticket prices directly limited or prevented attendance. These accounts indicate that the importance of price may vary according to venue, seating category, income, and comparisons with other leisure activities.

The effect of the Timothée Chalamet controversy: A1 and A5 believed that the Timothée Chalamet controversy increased interest in opera. A6 offered a contrasting prediction, suggesting that a high-profile dismissal could reinforce negative perceptions among some young people. Since the interviews captured participants' perceptions rather than changes in audience behaviour, these accounts should be treated as competing interpretations rather than evidence of the controversy's overall effect.

4.7 Summary of Results

Table 3. Overarching Themes and Sub-Themes

Major Theme	Sub-Theme
A. Discovery and Access Pathways	A1. Personal-network-mediated access
	A2. Passive and algorithmic digital discovery
	A3. Early and latent exposure
B. Content Engagement and Format Preferences	B1. Backstage and humanising content
	B2. Curated, risk-reduced entry-level content
	B3. Content-driven reach beyond the niche
	B4. Emotional and parasocial engagement mechanisms
C. Barriers to Attendance	C1. Price as a contested and variable barrier
	C2. Duration and format as an attentional barrier
	C3. Cultural capital and perceived legitimacy barriers
D. Institutional and Industry Strategy	D1. Funding and organisational context
	D2. Platform and promotional strategy
	D3. Institutional positioning and identity
E. Outcomes: Conversion and Audience Composition	E1. Direct and Gradual Pathways toward Attendance
	E2. Perceived persistence of a niche/insider-skewed audience
	E3. Non-purchase outcomes of content engagement

Source: own elaboration based on thematic analysis.

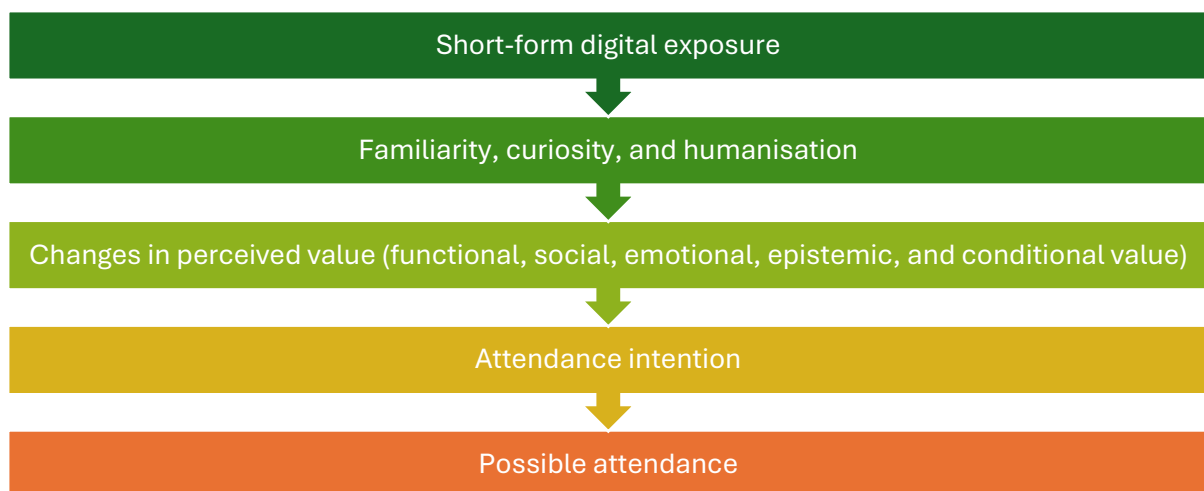
Section F presents six additional points of explicit divergence between participants, discussed above. Further set of single-mention codes were identified during coding; these are referenced

individually within the relevant sub-theme sections as supporting detail rather than restated here.

5. Discussion

This study examined how short-form digital content shapes opera's perceived value among young audiences with varying levels of familiarity with the art form, and under what conditions this may relate to attendance intention. The findings suggest a gradual and conditional process rather than a direct causal pathway. Short-form content may first create familiarity, curiosity, or a sense of connection by showing the people and processes behind opera. These changes may then influence how accessible, emotionally meaningful, socially relevant, or intellectually interesting opera appears. Attendance intention may develop at a later stage, but it is shaped by additional conditions, including prior familiarity, personal networks, algorithmic exposure, price perceptions, performance duration, and practical or cultural barriers.

The findings therefore suggest the following general process: Digital exposure → familiarity, curiosity, and humanisation → changes in perceived value → possible attendance intention. This process is not linear or universal. Some participants described short-form content as helping them discover events or decide which opera to attend, while others described content as influencing their general perception of opera without leading to a specific ticket purchase. Personal recommendations and existing cultural networks remained important access routes, while algorithmic feeds often reinforced existing interests rather than introducing opera to people with no prior connection to it. The relationship between digital content and attendance intention should therefore be understood as cumulative and conditional rather than immediate. Figure 1. Proposed process linking short-form digital content and attendance intention.



Source: own elaboration.

The process is shaped by prior familiarity, personal networks, algorithmic visibility, price perceptions, duration and format, cultural legitimacy, and practical access conditions.

5.1 Discovery and Access Pathways

Participants' accounts suggest that personal networks remained one possible route into opera, although this pathway was not described uniformly. A1 and A2 reported encountering opera through existing relationships, whereas A3 described social media as particularly useful because frequent travel limited her access to a stable local network. These accounts qualify, rather than contradict, Ouazzani et al.'s (2022b) argument that online channels can extend access beyond the physical venue. In this sample, social media appeared to complement personal networks in some cases and to provide an alternative route where such networks were less available. This raises the possibility that the access-extending role of digital content may vary according to an individual's existing social connections, although the present study cannot establish this relationship.

The accounts of A2, A6, and A7 further suggest that algorithmic feeds may reinforce existing interests rather than introduce opera to users with no prior connection to the art form. A6's account of not receiving opera-related content because he had never searched for it illustrates this limitation. This observation is consistent with Harcourt's (2015) critique of platform environments in which exposure is shaped by prior behaviour rather than by open discovery, although the present study does not provide evidence about the operation of algorithms beyond participants' perceptions.

Finally, A1, A4, and A5 described early and incidental encounters with opera through television or school-based exposure. These accounts are consistent with Benzecry's (2009) view of cultural appreciation as something that can be developed through engagement rather than simply inherited. They also raise the possibility that familiarity may begin before active interest emerges and may later influence how individuals respond to opera-related content. However, unlike Benzecry's ethnographic study, the present research does not examine the development of cultural appreciation over an extended period.

5.2 Content Engagement and Format Preferences

The strongest finding in this theme was the consistency with which participants valued backstage and humanising content. Nine participants across the industry and audience groups referred to content showing performers, technical staff, preparation, rehearsal, or other processes behind the finished performance. Participants appeared to value access to the people and processes normally hidden from the audience.

This finding relates to Ducros Passebois et al.'s (2019) discussion of the tension between the prestige associated with performing-arts institutions and the more informal communication styles of social media. The present findings suggest that humanising and process-based content may offer one possible way of negotiating this tension. However, the study cannot establish that this approach resolves the tension across opera institutions.

The accounts concerning content for beginners also relate to the Theory of Consumption Values. They suggest that short-form content can provide epistemic value by helping audiences learn about unfamiliar works and reduce uncertainty before attending. Participants' accounts also indicate emotional value, as they described opera-related content as calming, meaningful, entertaining, or personally engaging. This differs slightly from Ouazzani et al.'s (2022a) use of hedonic value: although both concepts concern positive experiences, this thesis applies the TCV category of emotional value to participants' accounts of feelings, mood, and personal responses to opera-related content.

Participants' accounts of performer-related engagement and mood regulation further suggest that short-form content may satisfy different motivations before any attendance decision is made. M6 described using opera-related content to feel calmer, while A5 described interest in a singer as a reason for attending a performance. These examples indicate that motivations for engaging with digital content and motivations for attending live opera may overlap, but they are not identical.

The findings also indicate that exposure to short-form content does not necessarily produce an immediate attendance decision. Participants more often described content as gradually changing their familiarity with, or general perception of, opera than as directly leading to a specific ticket purchase. Short-form content may therefore contribute to attendance intention by increasing familiarity, curiosity, or perceived accessibility, while the final decision remains shaped by personal networks, price, duration, location, and other practical conditions. This interpretation is consistent with the Experience Economy framework, which distinguishes the value of a live, immersive experience from the value of mediated content. Short-form content can reveal aspects of the people, preparation, and processes behind an opera production, but it cannot reproduce the complete sensory and social experience of attending a live performance.

5.3 Barriers to Attendance

The findings indicate that barriers to attendance were not limited to ticket price. Participants also referred to duration, format, unfamiliarity, perceived exclusivity, and uncertainty about the practical conditions of attending an opera. These barriers were

interconnected: a low-ticket price did not necessarily make attendance feel accessible if participants still viewed the venue, performance, or audience as intimidating.

Price was the most contested barrier. Some participants described opera tickets as expensive, particularly in certain venues or seating categories, while others considered them affordable when compared with major concerts or other leisure activities. This difference may reflect contrasting comparisons of functional value. For some participants, the relevant comparison was the absolute cost of a ticket; for others, it was the cost relative to alternative forms of entertainment. Discount schemes, seating categories, and regional differences further influenced these perceptions. The findings therefore suggest that price should not be treated as a uniform barrier across audiences.

The interviews also identified duration and format as possible barriers. A3 and A7 questioned whether very long performances fit contemporary patterns of attention. These accounts concern different aspects of accessibility: one relates to sustaining attention during a live performance, while the other concerns the technical quality of mediated content. The study cannot determine how widespread either issue is, but the findings suggest that both the length of the experience and the quality of its digital presentation may influence engagement.

Cultural capital and perceived legitimacy formed a further category of barriers. Participants described opera as intimidating, elitist, difficult to understand, or associated with people who already possessed specialised knowledge. M5 reported feeling intimidated by the Teatro Real despite his musical training, while A4 and A7 described interest in opera as something developed through repeated exposure and learning. These accounts are consistent with Benzecry's (2009) argument that opera appreciation can be acquired through processes of initiation and engagement rather than simply inherited. They also suggest that cultural capital may be domain-specific: musical training did not automatically remove participants' uncertainty about opera.

Participants' accounts further showed that practical information could influence perceived accessibility. A5 reported that people attending opera for the first time sometimes assumed that subtitles would not be provided. A2 and A8 described live attendance as challenging previous assumptions that opera was exclusively for wealthy or highly knowledgeable audiences. In these cases, direct experience appeared to be particularly important in changing perceptions. Short-form content may help prepare audiences by explaining subtitles, dress expectations, seating, duration, and the people involved in a production, but the interviews do not establish that digital content alone can overcome these barriers.

Overall, the findings suggest that attendance intention is shaped by the interaction between functional, cultural, and practical considerations. Price matters, but its importance depends on how it is framed and what alternatives participants use for comparison. Familiarity and perceived legitimacy may also influence whether a ticket is considered worth purchasing, while duration, location, subtitles, seating, and the social environment affect whether attendance feels manageable. These barriers should therefore be treated as related but distinct conditions rather than as a single general problem of affordability.

5.4 Institutional and Industry Strategy

The findings indicate that institutional conditions shape how short-form content is produced, distributed, and targeted. Participants referred particularly to available resources, organisational priorities, platform choices, promotional practices, and institutional positioning. These factors influenced not only what content could be created, but also whether it could reach audiences beyond the existing opera community.

Funding and organisational context appeared to affect the priority given to digital audience development. M4 suggested that public subsidy could reduce the immediate commercial pressure to attract additional ticket buyers, while M3 emphasised that limited resources require institutions to balance young-audience development with other organisational priorities. This finding is related to, but distinct from, Bellini and Raglianti's (2023) analysis of digital capabilities and readiness during the pandemic. Their study focuses on institutional adaptation under crisis conditions, whereas the present interviews highlight the continuing effects of resources, incentives, and strategic prioritisation on short-form content.

Platform and promotional strategy also shaped the potential reach of digital content. M3 argued that organic distribution might be insufficient, and that paid promotion could be necessary to increase visibility. M2 described using different platforms for different audience segments, while M4 associated Facebook with an older audience and Instagram with greater openness among younger users. M2's newsletter community, which provided recurring contact with more than 2,500 young people, further illustrated the value of communication channels owned by the institution rather than relying exclusively on platform algorithms.

Participants also identified practical and reputational constraints. M3 explained that one institution had not opened a TikTok account because it lacked the resources to maintain the platform effectively. M1 described the difficulty of working with influencers when their independent opinions do not fully align with an institution's promotional aims. A7 questioned whether institutions clearly identify the young audiences they are attempting to reach, suggesting that platform presence alone does not guarantee meaningful audience development.

Institutional positioning influenced the tone and intended audience of short-form content. M2 rejected an explicitly exclusive image and described affordability and accessibility as central to the institution's communication. He also indicated that youth-oriented projects were more likely to be effective when designed for younger audiences from the beginning rather than adapted retrospectively. M5 prioritised Spanish-language content to maintain a closer relationship with a specific audience rather than pursuing maximum international reach.

Overall, the findings suggest that short-form content is shaped by more than creative decisions. Resources, organisational priorities, platform strategies, paid promotion, owned communication channels, audience definition, and institutional identity all influence the conditions under which content can reach young audiences. At the same time, the study does not establish that any single institutional strategy is more effective than another.

5.5 Outcomes: Conversion and Audience Composition

The findings suggest that the relationship between short-form content and attendance intention is usually gradual rather than directly traceable. Three participants distinguished between content linked to a specific ticket purchase and content that slowly changed how people perceived opera more generally. They described the second pathway as more common, although the study did not measure actual content exposure or ticket purchases.

This finding extends the qualitative understanding of the different pathways identified in Ouazzani et al.'s (2022a) quantitative study of value, loyalty, and attendance intention. Their research demonstrates that value dimensions can influence behavioural outcomes through different pathways, while the present findings illustrate how participants understood these pathways in practice. M5 distinguished between promoting a specific performance and "democratising" opera's general image, while A5 described a gradual change in her associations with Turandot after repeated exposure to short-form content. These accounts suggest that changes in perceived value may occur before, and independently of, a specific attendance decision.

Participants also perceived the opera audience as relatively small and closely connected to the existing field. A1 described repeatedly seeing the same people at performances, while A5 referred to institutional concerns about the future size of the audience. A7 similarly suggested that many people consuming opera-related content were already connected to the sector. These accounts should be understood as participant perceptions rather than as direct evidence about the composition of the wider opera audience.

Cultural capital may help explain why participants perceived opera audiences as relatively insider oriented. Participants described opera as requiring familiarity with

conventions, knowledge, and forms of participation. This may make it easier for people already connected to the field to engage with opera content and live performances, while creating additional uncertainty for newcomers. However, the present study cannot determine whether this perceived audience composition is caused by cultural capital, marketing practices, institutional positioning, or other factors.

The interviews also revealed several outcomes that did not involve attendance. Participants described learning repertoire, developing professional knowledge, regulating mood, sharing content privately, seeking practical advice, and developing a sense of belonging. These outcomes suggest that the value of short-form content cannot be evaluated only through ticket purchases or immediate conversion.

Overall, the findings indicate that short-form content may contribute to attendance intention through a gradual process of increasing familiarity, curiosity, and perceived accessibility. However, the path is conditional and may not lead to attendance. Personal networks, price, practical access, cultural legitimacy, and the distinct value of the live experience continue to shape whether digital engagement develops into an intention to attend.

5.6 Making Sense of the Divergent Perspectives

Six points of genuine disagreement were identified among participants. These differences should not be treated as errors or inconsistencies, because they may reflect different expectations, experiences, and motivations among participants.

The first divergence concerned whether audiences should sample content before attending. M1 viewed short-form content as useful for obtaining “a taste” of an opera before committing to an entire evening, whereas A1 preferred to experience opera directly and without prior exposure. This difference may reflect contrasting preferences regarding uncertainty and novelty, although the present study cannot determine the reason for the difference.

A related divergence concerned the amount of narrative context audiences wanted before attending. M6 preferred to receive an introduction to an unfamiliar work, while A3 and A8 preferred to attend without researching the plot or receiving extensive explanation. A3 stated, “I want to go blank. Without expectations.” These contrasting accounts suggest that introductory content may be useful for some audiences but undesirable for others. The difference does not appear to correspond simply to familiarity with opera: A3 had substantial experience in the performing arts, while A8 was less familiar with opera. This raises the possibility that preferences for guidance or surprise may vary individually, although future research would be needed to examine this.

Participants also differed in their preferences for personality-driven content. M5, M6, A1, and A3 described content centred on performers' personalities or daily lives as engaging. A4 preferred content focused on musical knowledge and expressed concern that personality-driven content could become too focused on "the ego." One possible interpretation is that participants sought different types of value from short-form content. A4 may have been seeking primarily epistemic or informational value, while other participants may have valued social or performer-related connection. This interpretation remains tentative because it is based on a small number of accounts.

Another divergence concerned opera's relationship to digital fatigue. M6 suggested that some young people may value opera as an alternative to constant digital consumption. A2 described a contrasting preference among people in her social circle for staying indoors and watching series or films. These accounts represent competing possibilities rather than evidence of a single generational trend. The present study cannot determine which pattern is more widespread.

Participants also disagreed about the importance of price. M3 suggested that price might not be the main obstacle to attendance, whereas M2, M4, and M6 described situations in which ticket prices directly limited attendance. As discussed in Section 5.3, this difference may reflect contrasting comparisons of functional value: some participants evaluated opera against other leisure activities, while others focused on the absolute cost of tickets.

Finally, participants offered different interpretations of the Timothée Chalamet controversy. A1 and A5 believed that it increased curiosity about opera, while A6 predicted that a high-profile dismissal could reinforce negative perceptions. Because these accounts reflect participants' interpretations rather than measured changes in audience behaviour, the study cannot determine the controversy's overall effect. The divergence nevertheless shows that the same public event may be understood as either increasing curiosity or reinforcing distance from opera, depending on the audience member's prior attitudes and social context.

Taken together, these divergences suggest that there is no single audience response to short-form opera content. The value of contextual information, performer-focused content, live attendance, price, and public controversy depends on participants' existing familiarity, motivations, expectations, and social circumstances.

5.7 Unexpected Results

Three results were particularly noteworthy because they were not fully anticipated by the theoretical framework, or the literature reviewed.

First, backstage and humanising content was the most consistently valued content type in the interviews. Nine participants across the industry and audience groups referred to content showing performers, preparation, technical work, or other processes behind the finished performance. Existing research discussed the tension between the prestige of cultural institutions and the informal communication style of social media, but it did not specifically predict that process-based and human-focused content would be so consistently valued in this sample. The finding suggests that showing the people and work behind opera may be especially relevant to making the art form appear more approachable.

Second, participants more often described a gradual change in their general perception of opera than a direct link between one piece of content and one ticket purchase. This observation complicates a straightforward interpretation of research showing that perceived value can influence loyalty and attendance intention. Quantitative measures taken at one point in time may not fully capture the cumulative effect of content encountered over a longer period. However, because the present study relies on retrospective accounts and does not include behavioural or platform data, this interpretation should be treated as exploratory.

Third, A8's account raised the possibility that a positive live experience may not automatically lead to continued digital engagement. He described a favourable experience but did not subsequently follow the artists on social media. This observation comes from one participant and should not be treated as an established pattern. It nevertheless raises an important question for future research: whether post-attendance digital engagement follows automatically from a positive live experience, or whether institutions need to create separate strategies to maintain the relationship after attendance.

Together, these findings suggest that humanising content, gradual changes in perception, and post-attendance engagement deserve further investigation. They should be understood as contributions to future research rather than as causal conclusions established by the present study.

5.8 Discussion of the Research Objectives

The first objective examined how short-form digital content shaped the five dimensions of perceived value identified by the Theory of Consumption Values. The findings provide the clearest evidence for emotional, epistemic, social, and functional value. Emotional value appeared in participants' descriptions of opera as calming, meaningful, expressive, and capable of helping them feel less alone. Epistemic value was reflected in curiosity about unfamiliar works, backstage processes, performers, and suitable choices for a first opera. Social value emerged through personal recommendations, performer-related engagement, private sharing,

and attendance as a shared experience. Functional value was evident in participants' discussions of ticket prices, discounts, seating categories, and the practical use of short-form content for deciding whether or what to attend.

Conditional value was present, but less consistently. It appeared in accounts where circumstances such as a discounted ticket, an early school encounter, a cinema broadcast, travel, or access to a personal network made engagement possible. However, the interviews do not provide enough evidence to treat conditional value as a clearly established or equally prominent dimension. The findings therefore support a differentiated interpretation of TCV: emotional, epistemic, social, and functional value were more clearly visible, whereas conditional value appeared as a situational factor that influenced engagement in particular cases rather than as a consistent pattern across the sample. The second objective was to examine whether cultural capital, familiarity, and perceived legitimacy functioned as barriers independently of price. The findings suggest that they do. Participants referred to opera as intimidating, elitist, difficult to understand, or associated with particular social groups. Some described uncertainty about appropriate clothing, subtitles, language, architecture, and expected behaviour. Other accounts suggested that familiarity can be developed through repeated exposure and learning. Short-form content may help reduce these barriers by showing performers as approachable and by explaining the processes surrounding a performance, although several participants indicated that direct live experience was particularly important in changing perceptions of exclusivity.

The third objective was to distinguish the motivations for engaging with short-form opera content from the motivations for attending live performances. Participants engaged with short-form content for several reasons: curiosity, entertainment, mood regulation, professional learning, performer-related interest, social connection, and the desire to understand the people and processes behind a production.

Live attendance involved additional motivations and conditions. Participants referred to the value of a shared social occasion, the desire for a direct and surprising experience, emotional immersion, personal recommendations, and the opportunity to experience the complete combination of music, theatre, design, architecture, and performance. Attendance was also more strongly constrained by price, time, duration, location, and uncertainty about whether the experience would be accessible or enjoyable. Short-form content and live attendance therefore offered related but distinct forms of value rather than functioning as interchangeable experiences.

The fourth objective was to compare industry and audience perspectives. The two groups converged most clearly on the value of backstage and humanising content. Professionals described this content to make opera less intimidating, while audience participants independently described process-based and personality-related content as more engaging than formal performance footage.

The groups also revealed differences. Industry participants tended to discuss reach, platform strategy, paid promotion, newsletters, resources, institutional positioning, and the difficulty of tracing content exposure to ticket purchases. Audience participants focused more on personal discovery, emotional response, practical barriers, prior familiarity, and the conditions that made opera feel accessible or inaccessible. Comparing the two groups therefore made visible both a shared preference for more approachable content and a difference between institutional objectives and audience experiences.

Taken together, the four objectives are addressed through a model in which short-form content contributes primarily to familiarity, curiosity, emotional connection, and perceived accessibility. These changes may support attendance intention, but they do not determine it. Attendance remains dependent on personal networks, algorithmic visibility, price and practical conditions, cultural legitimacy, and the distinct value offered by the live experience. The comparison between industry and audience participants further indicates that effective audience development requires both appropriate content and an infrastructure capable of turning temporary digital attention into a sustained relationship.

6. Managerial Recommendations

The findings suggest three practical directions for opera institutions and creators using short-form digital content to engage younger audiences. These recommendations concern relationship-building, humanising and explanatory content, and the reduction of practical access barriers. Because the study is qualitative and based on a small, non-probability sample, the recommendations should be understood as context-sensitive implications rather than universally tested solutions.

6.1 Build Relationship Infrastructure, Not One-Off Content

The findings suggest that the relationship between short-form content and attendance intention is often gradual and difficult to attribute to one specific post or campaign. Institutions may therefore benefit from complementing short-form content with forms of relationship infrastructure, such as mailing lists, recurring invitations, newsletters, community groups, or other low-commitment communication channels.

The purpose of this infrastructure would be to maintain contact with audiences between individual content encounters and performances. M2's newsletter community, which provided recurring contact with more than 2,500 young people, illustrates one possible model within this dataset. However, the study does not establish that newsletters or owned channels automatically lead to attendance.

In practice, institutions could evaluate these activities through indicators such as repeat engagement, newsletter retention, replies, event enquiries, and the development of audience relationships over time, rather than relying only on views, likes, or short-term reach. Smaller organisations or individual creators could apply the same principle through a simple mailing list or a carefully managed community group, while larger institutions could use more developed audience-management systems.

Relationship infrastructure should not be treated as a substitute for content that creates initial interest. A7's account of unanswered invitations suggests that an existing relationship alone may not be sufficient when there is no baseline interest in opera. Relationship-building should therefore be combined with content that makes the art form more familiar and approachable.

6.2 Expand Humanizing Content into Active Teaching and Demonstrated Accessibility

Backstage and humanising content was the most consistently mentioned content type in the interviews. Institutions and creators may therefore consider continuing to show the people and processes behind opera, including performers, technical staff, rehearsals,

preparation, set construction, costume work, and other activities normally hidden from audiences.

The findings also suggest that humanising content could be complemented by explanatory content aimed at reducing uncertainty. Short videos could address practical and interpretive questions such as what subtitles look like, how to choose a first opera, what to expect from the venue, how long a performance lasts, and how seating categories differ. This approach would extend humanising content from showing who is involved in opera to helping audiences understand how the experience works.

The recommendation should remain focused on short-form content. Full performances, cinema broadcasts, and livestreams may contribute to broader audience development, but they are different formats and were not the central object of this study. They may be mentioned as possible complementary channels rather than as direct recommendations demonstrated by the present findings.

Content should also be adapted to different audience motivations. Some viewers may value performer-related or personality-driven material, while others may prefer concise musical or educational explanations. Institutions could therefore test different content categories rather than assuming one style will appeal equally to all young audiences.

6.3 Reduce Practical Access Barriers Directly

The findings suggest that institutions should address practical barriers through clear and specific communication. Short-form content can explain whether subtitles are provided, what ticket discounts are available, how seating categories differ, what the performance duration is, and what first-time attendees can expect from the venue.

This information should be communicated concretely rather than through general claims that opera is “accessible.” Participants’ accounts suggest that audiences may hold inaccurate assumptions about subtitles, prices, clothing, and the social expectations associated with attending opera. Providing specific information may help reduce uncertainty, although the study does not demonstrate that information alone changes attendance behaviour.

Institutions could also present ticket prices comparatively and transparently, showing the range of available seating and explaining youth or student discounts. Because participants evaluated opera prices in relation to concerts, theatre, and other leisure activities, comparative framing may be useful when communicating affordability.

Where relevant, institutions may also experiment with short explanatory formats about duration and performance structure. Any abridged or adapted versions should be clearly labelled as alternatives rather than presented as replacements for the complete work.

Overall, the findings suggest that the managerial challenge is not simply to produce more short-form content. It is to connect content with sustained communication and practical information so that audiences can move from curiosity to a more informed assessment of whether attending opera is feasible and worthwhile.

7. Limitations and Future Research

This chapter discusses the study's methodological limitations and identifies directions for future research. The main limitations concern participant recruitment, the qualitative and cross-sectional design, retrospective self-report, translation, coding, and the absence of behavioural or platform analytics.

7.1 Design and Data Limitations

The study used a small, non-probability sample recruited purposively, with some snowballing and self-selection. The final sample comprised six industry and professional participants and eight audience participants. Participants were selected because they had a relevant professional, creative, or personal connection to opera and social media. Consequently, the sample may overrepresent individuals who already have a positive or active relationship with opera and its digital presence.

This limitation may be particularly relevant to the findings concerning content engagement and emotional response. Participants who were sufficiently interested in opera to agree to a 45–60-minute interview may have responded more positively to opera-related content than people with no prior interest. The audience sample also included participants with different levels of familiarity with opera, but it did not include a sufficiently large group of people with no previous contact with the art form.

The industry sample of six participants provides useful professional perspectives but cannot represent the full range of opera institutions, creators, or organisational contexts. All professional participants had some connection to digital content or audience development. The study therefore does not include the perspectives of institutions that have chosen not to use short-form content or that lack the capacity to develop a digital strategy.

The study relies on retrospective self-report collected during single-session interviews. Participants described how content had shaped their perceptions and decisions, sometimes referring to experiences that occurred several years earlier. These accounts may be affected by the limitations of memory, including the possibility that participants reconstructed a clearer relationship between content exposure and later behaviour than existed at the time.

The qualitative, cross-sectional design also cannot establish causality between short-form content and attendance intention. The direct and gradual pathways described in Section 4.5.1 reflect participants' interpretations of their own experiences rather than behavioural evidence tracing exposure to a specific ticket purchase. No platform analytics, customer-relationship data, ticketing data, or longitudinal observations were available to verify these pathways.

A further limitation concerns the boundaries of the term “opera” within the dataset. One participant discussed a commercially operated, tourist-oriented opera experience in a Vienna palace. This account was retained as evidence concerning perceived accessibility but was distinguished from attendance at an institutional opera house. Future studies could either exclude such adjacent experiences or examine them as a separate category of cultural product.

The pilot interview also presented limitations. A recording failure and the participant’s very limited familiarity with opera led to changes in the interview guide and sampling approach before the main data collection. A more extensive pilot phase might have helped refine questions concerning audience expertise, post-attendance engagement, and the differences between digital and live motivations.

7.2 Translation and Coding

Interviews conducted in Spanish were transcribed and auto translated using TurboScribe and subsequently checked manually against the original recordings. Despite this verification process, translation from Spanish to English necessarily introduces an additional interpretive layer between a participant's original words and the English quotation, and some loss or shift of nuance cannot be fully ruled out even with careful manual review. The extensive verification process applied to the final coding table, in which every supporting quotation was checked against the original transcripts and cross-referenced across interviews, mitigates but does not eliminate the influence of a single researcher's interpretive judgement on which patterns were identified as themes.

7.3 Future Research

Several directions for future research follow from the findings and limitations of this study. First, the direct and gradual pathways described in Section 4.5.1 could be examined through a longitudinal design combining interviews, platform analytics, and ticketing data. Such research could follow participants over time and investigate whether repeated exposure to short-form content is associated with changes in perceived value, attendance intention, or actual attendance.

Second, future research could examine the role of personal networks more directly. The present findings raise the possibility that social media may function differently for people who already have personal connections to opera and those who do not. A comparative study involving participants with and without such networks could test this possibility.

Third, the relationship between price framing and attendance intention deserves further study. A quantitative survey or experimental design could distinguish between absolute price

sensitivity and the way prices are compared with other leisure activities. It could also examine whether clear communication about discounts, seating, subtitles, and duration changes perceived accessibility.

Fourth, future research could investigate whether prior familiarity or musical training influences preferences for personality-driven, backstage, educational, or performance-focused content. The present study identified different preferences, but the sample was too small to determine whether these differences were related to expertise, personal taste, or other factors.

Fifth, the exploratory observation concerning post-attendance digital engagement should be examined with a larger sample. A longitudinal study could investigate whether a positive live experience leads to subsequent following, sharing, or interaction with opera-related digital content, and which forms of institutional follow-up might support that relationship.

Finally, future research could extend the study to other geographic and institutional contexts. The present sample included participants from Western Europe and Latin America, with one participant from Ireland, but it did not represent all cultural contexts in which opera institutions use digital media. Comparative research could examine whether the roles of personal networks, cultural legitimacy, platform use, and short-form content differ across regions and opera traditions.

8. Conclusion

This study examined how short-form digital content on social media shapes the perceived value of opera among young audiences with varying levels of familiarity with the art form, and under what conditions this may relate to attendance intention. Drawing on fourteen semi-structured interviews six with industry and professional participants and eight with audience participants the study identified a gradual and conditional relationship rather than a direct causal pathway.

The findings suggest that short-form content may shape perceived value by increasing familiarity, curiosity, and emotional connection. This was most clearly illustrated by the frequent positive references to backstage and humanising content. Nine participants across both groups referred to content showing performers, technical staff, rehearsals, preparation, or other processes behind the finished performance. Such content appeared to make opera more approachable by giving audiences access to the people and work normally hidden from view. The findings also suggest that short-form content may influence perceptions of opera without immediately producing a specific ticket purchase. Participants described gradual changes in their general understanding of opera, including shifts in familiarity, associations, and perceived accessibility. A direct relationship between a particular video and a particular ticket purchase was described less frequently. However, because the study is based on retrospective interviews and does not include platform or ticketing data, it cannot establish whether short-form content causes changes in attendance intention or actual attendance.

Whether increased familiarity or perceived accessibility develops into attendance intention appears to depend on several conditions. Personal networks may facilitate access in some cases, while social media may provide an alternative route for people without a stable local connection to opera. At the same time, participants perceived algorithmic feeds as often reinforcing existing interests rather than introducing opera to people with no prior connection to it. Price, seating, duration, subtitles, location, unfamiliarity, and perceptions of cultural exclusivity also influenced whether attending opera appeared feasible and worthwhile.

The findings further indicate that motivations for engaging with short-form content are not identical to motivations for attending live opera. Participants engaged with digital content for curiosity, entertainment, emotional regulation, professional learning, performer-related interest, and social connection. Live attendance involved additional forms of value, including the sensory and social environment, the desire for a direct or spontaneous experience, and the opportunity to encounter the combination of music, theatre, design, and performance in person.

Short-form content may therefore prepare or encourage interest in opera, but it cannot reproduce the complete value of the live experience.

8.1 Contribution of the Study

This thesis makes two principal contributions. First, it extends research on opera streaming and perceived value by examining short-form social-media content rather than full-length streamed performances. It also focuses on young audiences with varying levels of familiarity with opera rather than on an already-engaged streaming audience. The study contributes a qualitative, participant-centred account of how short-form content may influence perceived value through familiarity, curiosity, emotional connection, and access to the people and processes behind an opera production.

The study also clarifies that the five dimensions of the Theory of Consumption Values did not emerge equally strongly. The findings provided the clearest evidence for emotional, epistemic, social, and functional value. Conditional value appeared more selectively, in relation to circumstances such as discounts, personal networks, early exposure, and access conditions. This differentiated finding avoids treating all five dimensions as equally supported by the data. Second, the comparison between industry and audience participants made several convergences and divergences particularly visible. Both groups referred to the value of backstage and humanising content, although professionals tended to discuss its strategic purpose while audience participants described their personal responses to it. The two groups also differed in emphasis: industry participants discussed platform strategy, resources, reach, and relationship-building, whereas audience participants focused more on discovery, emotional response, practical barriers, and the conditions that made opera feel accessible.

The study also identified several questions for further research. These include whether gradual exposure to short-form content can be observed through longitudinal behavioural data, whether personal networks affect the access-extending role of digital content, and whether different audiences prefer personality-driven or more substantive content. A8's account of a positive live experience that did not lead to subsequent digital engagement should be treated as an unexpected observation from one participant, not as an established contribution. It raises the question of whether positive attendance automatically produces an ongoing digital relationship, or whether institutions need specific post-attendance strategies to maintain engagement.

The study's findings suggest that short-form content should not be evaluated only through immediate ticket sales. Its contribution may also involve increasing familiarity, reducing perceived distance, supporting learning, generating emotional or social value, and

creating the conditions under which attendance becomes more conceivable. At the same time, these possible effects remain dependent on practical, cultural, institutional, and personal conditions that short-form content alone cannot resolve.

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Appendix

Interview Guide for young audience

Opening:

Hi [name], thank you so much for agreeing to talk with me today I really appreciate it. My name is Martyna, and I'm a master's student at the Universitat Autònoma de Barcelona. I'm doing research on how young people discover and relate to opera through what they come across on social media.

I want to be clear that I am not testing your knowledge of opera, and there are no right or wrong answers. I'm genuinely curious about your personal experience what you watch, how you feel about it, what goes through your head. Your opinion is what matters here.

With your permission, I'd like to record our conversation so I can focus on listening rather than taking notes. The recording will be transcribed, anonymised, and then deleted your name will never appear in anything I write. Do you have any questions before we begin? Great let's start.

1. Warm up:

To start could you just tell me a little bit about yourself?

What does your day-to-day life look like?

What do you study or do for work? Where do you live?

What do you do in your free time what do you enjoy?

Who do you spend most of your time with friends, family, partner?

In terms of going out to concerts, exhibitions, the cinema, theatre, gigs how much of that is part of your life?

What kinds of cultural events do you go to most often? With whom?

Is going to cultural events something your family did when you were growing up?

Do you feel like you are 'a cultural person'? What does that even mean to you?

2. Social Media:

Which social media platforms do you use on a regular basis? Could you walk me through a typical day of using them?

When do you open them morning, commute, before bed, all the time?

Are there platforms you use mainly to watch things, and others you use to communicate?

Roughly how much time a day do you think you spend scrolling honestly?

When you are scrolling say on TikTok or Instagram Reels what kinds of videos do you tend to stop and watch?

What makes you stop?

Is it the first second of the video? The thumbnail? Someone you follow.

What makes you keep watching past the first few seconds?

What makes you immediately swipe past?

Do you ever share or save videos? What kinds of things do you save or send to people?

What does it mean to you when you share something with someone are you saying something about yourself?

Have you ever saved a video to come back to later and gone back to it?

Do you follow any accounts or creators related to music, arts, or culture on social media? Which ones?

How did you first come across them?

What do they do that keeps you interested?

Are there cultural or arts accounts that you followed for a while and then stopped following? Why?

3. Opera on Social Media

Have you ever come across anything related to opera on social media on TikTok, Instagram, YouTube Shorts, or anywhere else? Tell me about that.

What was it a clip, a reel, a story, a meme?

Do you remember roughly when that was, or what platform?

Did you go looking for it, or did it just appear in your feed?

Can you tell me about one specific video related to opera that you remember seeing online the one that comes most readily to mind? Walk me through it as if you're describing it to a friend who hasn't seen it.

What was happening in the video what was shown, what was heard?

Who posted it an opera house, an individual singer, a media account, a friend?

How long was it roughly? Did you watch the whole thing?

What were you doing when you watched it where were you, what time of day?

Take me through what went through your mind while you were watching it what did you think, what did you feel?

Were you surprised by anything in the video itself, or by your own reaction?

Did it change at any point did you start sceptical and warm to it, or the reverse?

Did you feel anything emotionally moved, impressed, amused, uncomfortable?

What did you do immediately after watching it?

Did you watch another video? Look something up? Send it to someone?

Or did you just scroll on and forget about it?

Did you talk about it with anyone in real life or online?

Looking back at that experience or those experiences did opera content on social media change anything about how you think or feel about opera?

Did it make it seem more interesting, or more accessible, or more relatable or not at all?

Did it make opera feel like something that could be for you or did it still feel like something for other people?

Was there a specific moment, video, or performer that shifted something for you, even slightly?

4. Real Experience from Short Content

When you watch a short video related to opera a clip, a reel, a behind-the-scenes moment what do you get out of it? What does it do for you?

Is it mainly entertaining? Or is it more that it teaches you something you didn't know?

Does it give you a sense of what opera feels like the atmosphere, the emotion, the scale of it?

Or does it feel more like a very distant window interesting but not really close to the real thing?

Has short-form content ever made you curious about opera wanting to find out more, listen to a full aria, or look something up?

What was it about the content that sparked that curiosity?

And did you act on it did you look anything up, or did the curiosity pass quickly?

Opera has a reputation for being quite serious, formal, or even intimidating. When you see it on social media, does that image change at all?

Does seeing a singer be funny or casual in a reel make them feel more human? Does that matter to you?

Or does making opera 'fun' on social media feel a bit forced or artificial to you?

Is there a risk that the social media version of opera gives you a wrong impression makes it seem simpler or lighter than it is?

Is there anything you feel that short videos about opera simply cannot give you something that only actually being there in the opera house could give?

What do you imagine the live experience gives you that a 60-second clip never could?

Is that a reason to go? Or does it feel like an argument that the two things are just completely different and not related?

5. Opera in real life

You have been to the opera at least once could you tell me about the experience that comes most readily to mind? Tell me the whole story before, during, and after.

How did the idea of going come about whose idea was it? Did you go with someone?

How did you prepare, if at all? Did you listen to the opera beforehand, look anything up, watch anything online?

What was the first impression when you arrived the building, the audience, the atmosphere?

And during the performance itself what do you remember most vividly? What was going through your mind?

Was there a moment that surprised you, moved you, confused you, or bored you?

Was it that you had expected or was it different, better or worse?

How did you feel in your body during the performance relaxed, tense, transported, self-conscious?

What happened after? What did you do, think, feel once it was over?

Did you talk about it with whoever you went with, with friends, family?

Did you go looking for anything online afterwards the opera, the singer, the composer?

Did it leave you wanting more, or feeling like once was enough?

Now thinking back to any short-form content related to opera you've seen online do you see any connection between that and your decision or desire to go to the opera? Or are they separate things in your mind?

Did something you saw online ever make you think 'I'd like to see that live'?

Or was the decision to go completely independent of social media through a friend, a class, a coincidence?

Is there a video, a performer, or a moment online that you would now love to experience live?

6. Opera problems

What would stop you from going to the opera more often than you do? What are the things that get in the way?

Is it mainly practical cost, distance, time?

Or is it more social not having people to go with, not feeling like it's 'your world'?

Is there anything about the opera house itself the atmosphere, the dress code, the audience that feels like a barrier?

Is there something about the art form itself the language, the length, the seriousness that puts you off?

Do you ever feel like opera is 'not really for people like me' or that there's a kind of person who goes to the opera, and you're not sure you're that person?

Where does that feeling come from, do you think?

Has it ever changed have you ever felt like opera was for you?

Did seeing opera content on social media affect that feeling at all?

What would make you more likely to go to the opera what would need to be different?

A friend who really wanted to go. A cheaper ticket? A shorter or more modern production?

Knowing more about what was going to happen before you arrived?

Finding a singer or performer you already felt connected to through social media, for instance?

If an opera house had a great social media presence really engaging short videos, a singer you loved following would that make you more likely to go to one of their performances?

Or would you keep those two things separate in your mind the online world and the live world?

Has that ever actually happened did following someone online lead you to buy a ticket?

7. Ideal future for Opera

If you could design your perfect experience of discovering opera from first encounter to being there in the audience, what would it look like?

What would you want to see first online before deciding to go?

What would make the live experience feel welcoming and right for you?

Is there a version of opera a format, a venue, a presentation that you think you would genuinely love?

Do you think you'll go to the opera again in the next year or two? What would make that more or less likely?

Is there a particular production, singer, or city you'd want to see?

Would you go alone, or does it need to be a social thing?

We're coming to the end thank you so much for sharing all of this with me. Your answers are genuinely useful, and I really appreciate how open you've been.

Is there anything you'd like to add something you feel we didn't cover, or something you want to go back to?

Thank you so much this has been a valuable conversation. I'll be in touch if I have any follow-up questions. Have a great rest of your day!

Goodbye and thank you.

Interview Guide for professionals

Opening:

Hello, my name is Martyna. Thank you very much for agreeing to this interview. I am a master's student at the Universitat Autònoma de Barcelona, working under the supervision of Professor Yacine Ouazzani. My research focuses on how short-form digital content on platforms such as TikTok, Instagram Reels, or YouTube Shorts may shape the way young audiences perceive and value opera, and whether this can eventually encourage them to attend a live performance.

As someone working at [name of institution], your perspective on strategy, content creation, and audience engagement is extremely valuable. If you do not mind, I would like to record this conversation so that I can transcribe and analyse it more carefully. The recording will be deleted once transcribed, and your identity will be anonymised in the thesis and in any related academic output, unless you explicitly agree otherwise. Do you have any questions before we begin? Thank you. Let's start.

1. Warm up question introduction:

Very short, could you briefly introduce yourself and tell me about your role at [name of institution]?

How long have you been in this position? What did you do before?

What does your day-to-day work look like? What occupies most of your time?

How did [name of institution] come to exist, and how has its mission evolved since you joined?

How would you describe [name of institution] overall mission, and where does digital content sit within that mission?

Is there a change over time say, pre- and post-pandemic?

2. Platform strategy and short-form content:

I know that currently you produce short-form content videos under roughly 90 seconds on platforms such as TikTok, Instagram Reels, or YouTube Shorts, my question is:

When did you begin doing this? What prompted it?

I noticed that [name of institution] have experimented with different short-form platforms:

How do you decide whether to continue, pause, or stop using a platform?

Are there other formats you have tried and abandoned? Why? And what is the future of them?

How do you decide what short-form content to create?

Could you walk me through the process from idea to publication?

Who is involved in-house team, external creators, partner institutions?

What roles do opera houses themselves play in supplying content or shaping what you produce?

When you produce short-form content for [name of institution] and opera houses, who are you trying to reach?

Could you describe your ideal audience for this type of content?

What is the goal on platforms like TikTok Instagram YouTube Shorts?

How do you distinguish between content for existing opera lovers and content for people who have never attended an opera?

What types of short-form content tend to perform best in your experience?

For example: behind-the-scenes footage, short aria clips, singer interviews, educational explainers, rehearsal moments...

What is it about these formats that makes them more effective, do you think?

3. What short-form content does for audiences

In your opinion what can make young people curious about opera?

How do you think short-form content can change the way young audiences perceive opera for example, by making it feel more accessible, less intimidating, or less elitist?

Can it make someone who has never considered going to the opera curious enough to consider attending?

Which barriers can digital content realistically lower: unfamiliarity, social intimidation, perceived elitism, cost perception?

Have you deliberately created content to challenge those perceptions? Can you give me an example?

How do you think the emotional experience of watching a short clip relates to the emotional experience of attending a live performance?

How does a clip give a 'taste' of what the live experience feels like, or does it give something else entirely?

4. Audience development and conversion to live attendance:

Do you have any evidence, data, audience research or anecdotal feedback that people who first encountered opera through [name of institution] digital content have subsequently attended a live performance?

How do you know? What data sources do you have access to?

Are there moments in the content journey a particular video, a particular interaction that seem to be turning points?

What do you think needs to happen between someone watching a short opera video and deciding to buy a ticket?

What is the journey between those two moments?

Is it a single video that tips someone over, or an accumulation of exposure over time?

Are there things [name of institution] or opera houses do, or could do, to bridge that gap more actively?

➔ Young audiences are often cited as the target for digital audience development. Do you think short-form content reaches young people who are genuinely new to opera people with no prior contact with the art form?

Or does it tend to reach people who are already somewhat interested, but perhaps haven't yet attended?

Opera houses vary enormously in their digital maturity and willingness to engage with short-form content.

What differences do you observe, and how does that affect what [name of institution] can do?

Are there institutions that are genuinely enthusiastic who see short-form content as a strategic priority?

Are some institutions more cautious or sceptical about short-form content? If so, what explains this hesitation in your view?

5. Critical reflections: limits and tensions:

In your opinion what are the limits of short-form digital content as a tool for opera audience development what are those limits?

What has not worked, despite expectations?

If resources and constraints were no obstacle, what would [name of institution] ideal short-form content strategy for young audiences look like?

In your opinion, what is the main difficulty in developing such a strategy?

What would you create that you cannot create today?

What would success look like in five years, and how would you know it had worked?

Looking ahead how do you see the role of short-form content in the opera sector evolving? Will it become more central, or will it remain a secondary channel?

Are there technologies AI-generated content, immersive formats, co-creation tools that you think will change the picture fundamentally?

Is there anything you would like to add something you feel we have not covered, or something you would like to clarify, or correct?

Thank you very much for your time and for the depth of your answers. Your practitioner perspective is extremely valuable for my research.

Is there anyone else you think I should contact for this research?

Your insights are genuinely valuable to this research. I will be in touch once the analysis is complete, and I would be delighted to share my findings with you if that would be useful.

Thank you again.

Representative extract from the category matrix

	A6	" we love like reality TV and stuff because you want to see the person behind the show."
	A5	a Teatro alla Scala video resolving a historical pronunciation debate, paired with rare production footage — " very, very interesting."
	A3	" maybe I' m less used to that information" (vs. footage of " how the singer sings").
	A1	" opera singers... normal people. People who go to Mercadona to shop just like us."
	M6	" they have a camera in the audience and you see just the empty stage and then all the workers come in and they' re building the scenery... for those I will always sit there and watch the whole thing." " if they show me a clip of the product then I' m interested and I' ll sit there and watch it"
	M5	" my job today is to spend the afternoon with my friend while she prepares to do the show... this girl is a girl like you and me... to humanize the opera so that people aren' t afraid of it."
	M4	" come backstage, get in touch with the singers."
	M2	" to humanize the theatre through the people who are part of it... telling you a part of the process of their work."
	M1	" behind the scenes can, can work well." " we love it when people make their own versions, use our music and then record their own... in their bedrooms" " interviews, you know, talking heads. It' s a bit boring."
Sub-theme		B1. Backstage and humanizing content as an engagement driver
Major theme		B. Content Engagement and Format Preferences